

Using the PlayStation 3 to study black holes

Putting LAN gaming groups to shame, gravity researchers [have wired](#) 16 PlayStation 3's together to make a black-hole-calculating supercomputer. A University of Alabama in Huntsville and University of Massachusetts, Dartmouth, team combined the consoles to crack scientific uncertainty over how quickly rotating black holes stop vibrating.

"If we had rented computing time from a supercomputer center it would have cost us about \$5,000 to run our [black hole] simulation one time. For this project we ran our simulation several dozens of times to test different parameters and circumstances," study author Lior Burko told Inside Science News Service.

The [study](#) appears in the Classical and Quantum Gravity journal. The PlayStation cluster can solve some astrophysical problems -- ones involving many calculations but low memory usage -- in one day, equaling the speed of a rented super-computer.

By Dan Vergano

Photo: A PlayStation 3 (Sony)